

Is AI wasting water a genuine concern people should have, or is it just fear mongering that the internet likes to do?

Posted by u/Tolnin • 0 points • 17 comments

I hear this all the time and, if true, it's the only actually good argument against AI that I've heard imo and it would probably make me against AI if it is indeed true

And is it just image / video generation that's causing this or is it even the simple texting you can do with AI like asking ChatGPT a recipe or something?

Cite sources if you can pls

Comments

u/Cheap-Bit-6803 • 0 points • 2026-02-27 02:18 UTC

"Would probably make me against AI if it is indeed true" are you fucking kidding me dude? The fuck do you mean "probably" ????

u/m0le55 • 1 points • 2025-11-20 21:48 UTC

Chat gpt runs on open ai, open ai uses close loop water usage for cooling down data centers, basically yes ai is using water to cool down data centers but many pepole are thinking about solution (gray water, air cooling, building data centers in cold areas, water cycles). When saying it uses water, it can lead to local water stress but not global scale water stress

u/Cliffy73 • 4 points • 2025-10-18 22:30 UTC

It's true in the sense that AI isn't generating anything useful by consuming all that energy.

u/natasa_yнна • 3 points • 2025-10-18 22:19 UTC

yeah that's a real concern even simple chat queries use data centers which need water for cooling and image or video generation uses way more it's not just hype the scale of ai operations adds up fast and affects water usage globally

u/DiogenesKuon • 1 points • 2025-10-18 22:03 UTC

Like most things on the internet it's massively blown out of proportion. In 2023 the cooling for all data centers (not just AI), used 17 billion gallons for the year. The US uses 322 billion gallons of water A DAY. So data centers are using 0.01% of our water.

u/Tolnin • 3 points • 2025-10-18 22:06 UTC

2023 is kind of outdated at this point with how much bigger and more advanced AI has gotten since then. Do you have more recent statistics and source if possible?

u/DiogenesKuon • 2 points • 2025-10-18 22:12 UTC

We don't get real time data, and often have to look back multiple years when we talk about things like this. But even if you think the amount of data centers have doubled since 2023 (which no one actually thinks) you are still at 0.028%

u/Tolnin • 1 points • 2025-10-18 22:27 UTC

Okay yeah that's fair

u/AgentElman • 3 points • 2025-10-18 21:37 UTC

Using AI to generate things takes up almost no power or water. So you asking AI a question it uses almost no resources.

But companies set up vast data warehouses with thousands of servers - and those use up some water. And they make a lot of those data warehouses.

It's like asking if watering a plant uses up a lot of water and then using the total water usage for all non-farm irrigation and saying it uses a ton of water.

So should you not water your plant because there are lots of golf courses being watered in Texas?

u/zaevilbunny38 • 3 points • 2025-10-18 22:14 UTC

To answer your question yes there are plenty of times you should not water your plants or lawns, even if they do it in Texas. Also yes they use vast amount of water and electricity and will likely have priority access should a drought happen in the area.

<https://www.orentcrimallaw.com/blog/can-i-be-fined-for-watering-my-lawn-during-a-drought-in-arizona/>

u/hellshot8 • 6 points • 2025-10-18 21:39 UTC

thats sortof a dishonest comparison. peoples usage of chatGPT and sora is why those data warehouses exist, whereas me watering my plant has nothing to do with how a farm irrigates

u/Tolnin • 1 points • 2025-10-18 21:46 UTC

Yeah I completely agree, it's the snowball effect that many people seem to not understand

Like, for example, lets say Walmart did something bad and someone stops shopping at Walmart for that reason, they're making almost no difference in the slightest. But it's the fact that they're attempting to start something that can snowball into more and more people stopping their shopping at Walmart. If one person starts, more are likely to follow

For a more real example, veganism. I'd say even ten or twenty years ago, there was basically no support for it and it'd be so hard to get good vegan meals. But now, after more and more people start supporting the cause, there are all kinds of stuff for vegans to choose from. Even fully dedicated vegan restaurants

People always jump to the "you're not making a difference" argument when it's a pretty poor argument imo

u/hellshot8 • 2 points • 2025-10-18 21:48 UTC

i think there are instances where the argument "your personal behavior doesnt really impact things", but specifically image/video generation with AI costs a HUGE amount of compute power. sam altman has specifically talked about this

u/bt123456789 • 1 points • 2025-10-19 02:19 UTC

it does, seriously, poke around self hosting like r/StableDiffusion and some of the rigs are nuts.

now amplify that by hundreds of thousands and you get what the big datacenters consume.

I'm of the "AI is a useful tool if you use it right," variety, but acting like it consumes next to nothing is at best naivety.

u/Partnumber • 10 points • 2025-10-18 21:34 UTC

It is [a real issue](<https://www.eesi.org/articles/view/data-centers-and-water-consumption>) but it's also not exclusive to ai.

The question then becomes if you think that the benefit of AI outweighs the resources that are consumed to run it

u/Quiet_Ad639 • 1 points • 2025-11-08 08:03 UTC

Respectfully the source you linked sucks and is super misleading

u/HashPandaNL • 1 points • 2025-10-18 22:07 UTC

FYI: your source is riddled with misleading statements and some straight up misinformation.

u/fauxdeuce • 2 points • 2025-10-18 21:52 UTC

Issue yes, worse than nestle nooooooooo

u/nefelipd • 1 points • 2025-11-13 21:52 UTC

What's the problem with nestle?

u/fauxdeuce • 2 points • 2025-11-13 23:00 UTC

Corrupt people allowed nestle to buy water rights in places suffering from droughts and shortages of water. They further capitalize on loose regulations, poor oversight, and expired permits. So nestle then takes this water bottles it up and ships it out of state, out of the region, and in some cases out of country.

u/amakai • 4 points • 2025-10-18 22:13 UTC

You mean "not yet"

u/hellshot8 • 6 points • 2025-10-18 21:33 UTC

it is a genuine concern, its also driving up electricity costs